

Critical Conversations

TOPIC LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Upon successful completion of this topic, the student will be able to:

1. Recognize principles of consideration and candor that enable effective leadership.
2. Recognize the impact of bias on decision making.
3. Understand the linkage between a culture of awareness, individual character, and optimal organizational performance.
4. Understand the need to resolve contentious issues expeditiously in the best interest of the organization, recognizing the existence of different perspectives.
5. Identify specific techniques for improving performance within the workplace.

STUDENT PREPARATION

Student Support Material

1. People Skills Handbook, Aanstadd-Corbett-Jourdan-Pearman, 2012

Primary References

1. For Your Improvement, Korn Ferry, 2019, Eighth Edition
2. Navy Necessary Conversations Guide, Version 3.0, April 2024 (draft)
3. EDO School Note “Non-Attribution Policy”

Additional References

Introduction

- This is an opportunity to practice engagement in challenging discussions
  - Facilitator's role
    - Provide relevant academic lessons
    - Guide an open dialogue

- Rules Of Engagement (ROE)
  - Involve everyone, teach back and be transparent
  - Non-attribution environment; bounded, but honest discussion

Assumptions

- What do “assumptions” have to do with critical thinking?
- Why is it important to validate your assumptions?
  - We all operate with a unique view of the world
  - Bad assumptions lead to bad decisions
- Real life examples…
  - Effects of bad assumptions
  - Assumptions proven good

So What…

- Preformulated opinions can impair our ability to Get Real, Get Better (GRGB)
  - "Critical thinking requires a recognition of your biases." – MaryAnn Watson, DAU
  - Critical thinking drives necessary rigor into our decision-making and problem-solving
  - Sometimes the barriers to optimal performance lie below the surface and our assumptions prevent us from seeing them
  - How does this affect innovation?

Emotional Intelligence (EQ)

- A vital set of skills that enable individuals to understand, manage, and utilize emotions effectively, both personally and interpersonally
  - Enhanced employee engagement by connecting with the team on an emotional level, understanding their needs, and motivating them effectively
  - Proficiency in recognizing how one's own emotions influence the team, allowing them to manage their responses and interactions in ways that promote a positive work environment

Emotionally intelligent leaders can navigate disputes with empathy and tact, fostering constructive resolutions and maintaining team cohesion

Preparing for a Difficult Conversation

- Recognize that different perceptions about the same reality can exist
  - We can all be right. Individual assumptions play a role. Embracing this understanding can lead to a path for resolution
- Create a convenient time and a "safe space" for the conversation
  - Be open and vulnerable; likely to be reciprocated
- Understand Human Motivation (3 Hs)
  - Heart, Head, Hand
- Understand Human Reaction (5 Fs)
  - Fight, Flight, Freeze, Fawn, Flop
- Apply Emotional Intelligence (EQ)
- Check your assumptions
  - Know yourself and your audience
  - Be aware of flawed logic

Avoiding pre-determination of the outcome is paramount

Flawed Logic

- Familiarize yourself with common assumptions and generalizations that influence false conclusions and distractions:
  - ***Straw Man Fallacy***. Oversimplification or misrepresentation of someone's argument makes it easier to challenge or refute
  - ***Causal Fallacy***. Assuming that one event caused another, without ample proof of the connection, accelerates decision-making
  - ***Authority Fallacy***. Accepting a claim as true simply because an authority figure stated it simplifies decision-making
  - ***Horn effect***. A single attribute can form a complete view of someone
  - ***Halo effect***. A person who is well-liked can do no wrong
  - ***Bandwagon effect***. The majority opinion should prevail
  - ***Anchor effect***. The first piece of information received shapes the decision

Flawed Logic (cont'd)

- ***Sunk cost effect***. Time and money invested justifies continuance
- ***Attribution effect***. Judging oneself by intent, while others are judged by their actions, is perfectly valid
- ***Over-attribution effect***. A person's individual behavior is determined by their abiding personal values and attitudes
- ***Confirmation effect***. Evidence that supports an expectation overshadows contradictory evidence
- ***Prototype effect***. Someone seems to fit the mold, therefore they are the perfect fit
- ***Affinity effect***. The one that is most liked has instant advantage over the others
- Others?

Accomplishing a Difficult Conversation

- Set a neutral tone
  - Shared beliefs or values (common ground) could be a good starting point
- Build trust
  - Engage with dignity & respect, listen actively, assume positive intent
- Avoid blame; remember, we are a team. Learn from mistakes and move on
  - Start with "I" instead of "You" (e.g., "***I*** didn't receive..." vs "***You*** didn't deliver…" or "Help ***me*** understand…" vs "Why did ***you***…")
- Passion is good…until it impacts the ability to think and respond objectively
- Apply empathy; ask open-ended questions; more listening than talking
  - Embrace the power of "why"
- Talk about solutions or ways to avoid the unpleasant situation in the future
- Don't presume a complete resolution from the initial discussion
- If conversation becomes confrontational, reframe it (defuse the situation)

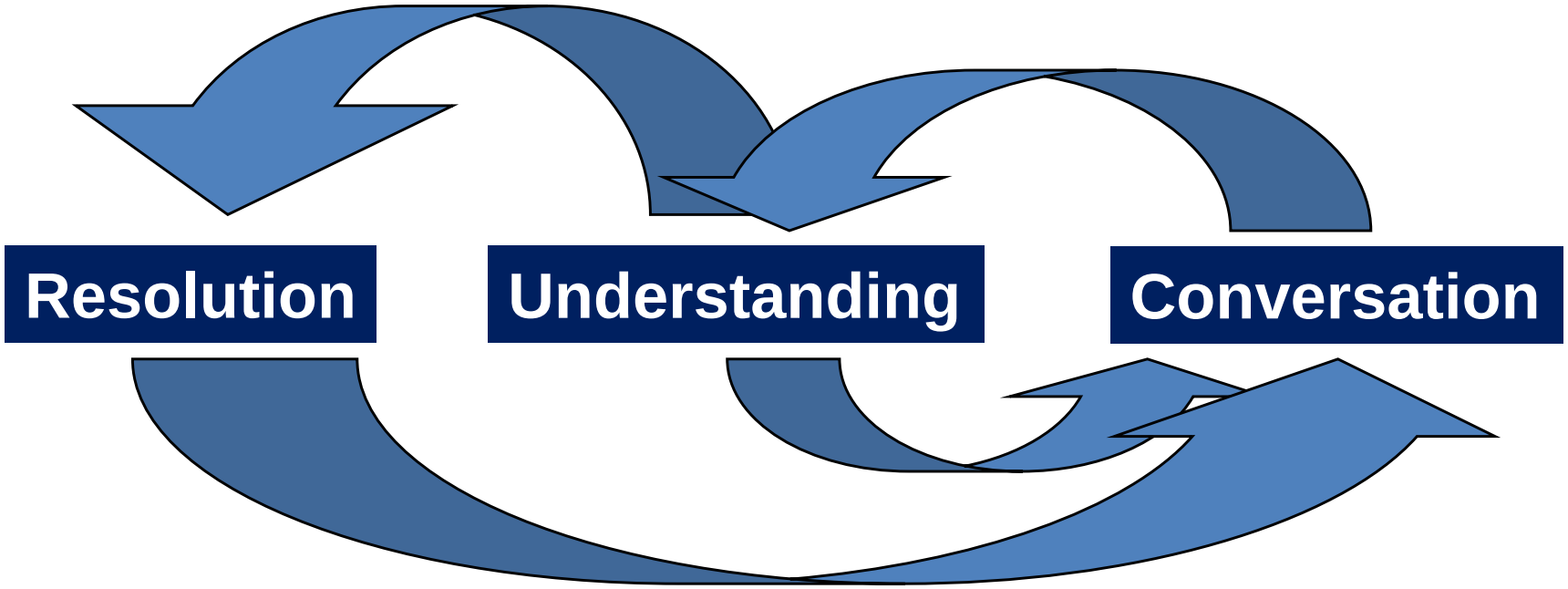
Key components: ***Trust, Authenticity, Openness, Patience, and Courage***

Candor With Senior Leadership

- Maintain humility
  - You may be the expert on the issues, engage with dignity & respect
- Are you well-versed in all relevant facts?
- Focus on solutions while providing clarity on root causes of prior issues
  - An elevator pitch may be useful here (see backup)
- Remember, we are on the same team and this is all about helping the team
- Direct > Ambiguous
- Anticipate concerns
- Don’t presume a decision from the initial discussion

Closing

- Your ability to properly address contentious situations is especially important at this stage of your career



Every conversation is a potential game-changer

Backup

Communicating for Buy-In

Concise Statement of the Issue + Resolution

Stop and ask yourself:

"Does this accurately summarize the desired outcome??"

#1 Strategic Message

Evidence to support

#2 Strategic Message

Evidence to support

#3 Strategic Message

Evidence to support

Goal is to get approval for your proposed action OR follow-up meeting

Call to Action

Sound Bites

- “Respond to adversity; don’t react.” – Tony Dungy
- “Communicating is more than speaking; it involves your entire presence.” – NAVEDTRA 134
- “The more senior you become, the more you should listen.” – VADM Moore (ret)
- “What people believe prevails over the truth.” – Sophocles
- “You can’t make good decisions unless you have good information and can separate facts from opinions and speculation.” – Gen. Colin Powell
- “The initial reaction might be the most uninformed response.” – Tim Haney
- “Toughness and empathy are not incompatible.” – Robert Greene
- “Certainty is no substitute for clarity.” – Dr. Robert Radi
- “To be confident and not delusional is a real skill.” -- Katt Williams
- “Show up with humility.” – CAPT Jon Gandy
- “It’s not what you say, it’s what they hear.” – Red Auerbach
- “Turn up the gain on your receiver.” – RDML Mike Do
- “Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our power to choose our response.” – Viktor Frankl